Lesson 28: Pronunciation: Reduced Words

English Stage 1 (B1) · Unit 3: Zero Waste

Adapted from Speaking, Listening and Pronunciation Projects for ELLs - Intermediate Level by Brittany Zemlick, Grossmont College (CC BY 4.0): 3.5 Reduced Words.

In this lesson

In natural English, small function words like "to", "and" and "of" are short and weak. We say they are reduced. You will learn how common function words sound when they are reduced, how speakers drop the "h" in words like "he" and "her", and how to hear the difference between "can" and "can't".

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Recognise reduced function words in natural speech.
- Say common function words in their reduced form, for example to = /tə/.
- Drop the "h" in he, him, her, his, have, has and had in the middle of a phrase.
- Hear and say the difference between "can" and "can't".
- Read sentences with stressed content words and reduced function words.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
reduced word	a function word said short and weak	to = /tə/
schwa /ə/	the most common English vowel: a short, relaxed sound, as in the first sound of "about"	can = /kən/
function word	a small grammar word (article, preposition, pronoun, auxiliary, conjunction)	to, for, at, and, or
content word	a word with the important information; it is stressed	toothpaste, make, easy
de-stressed	not stressed; said quickly and quietly	"for" in "I had eggs for breakfast."
drop the h	not say the /h/ sound	What did he do? = What didee do?
link	join a word to the word before it	Send her = Sender
can	usually reduced, with a schwa	Lauren can make toothpaste.
can't	said with a clear /æ/ as in "apple"	I can't make toothpaste.

Rules and explanations

Commonly reduced function words

Function words are usually not stressed, so they become short and weak. Most reduced forms use the schwa /ə/.

Full form	Reduced form (what it sounds like)	Example sentence
to	/tə/	You should talk to Charlie.
for	/fər/	I had eggs for breakfast.
at	/ət/	I'll see you at school.
and	/ən/, /ɪn/ or /n/	I'll have the soup and sandwich, please.
or	/ər/	Tea or coffee?
you	/yə/	Do you like it?
him, her	/əm/, /ər/	I called him last night. / I called her last night.
have	/əv/ or /ə/	Where have you been?
can	/kən/	I can sing. Can you?
do	/də/	What do you want?
as	/əz/	Light as a feather, stiff as a board.
of	/əv/ or /ə/	I'd like a cup of tea, please. / He gave me a box of apples.

- /ɪ/ is the short vowel as in "sit". In /yə/, the y is as in "yes".
- "Of": /əv/ is often used before a vowel sound (All /əv/ our friends were there). /ə/ is often used before a consonant sound (There were a lot /ə/ people).

Drop the "h"

- When structure words such as **her, he, him, his, have, has** or **had** are in the middle of a phrase, the h sound is often dropped. The word then links to the word before it.
  - What did he do? = What didee do?
  - Will he call me? = Willy call me?
  - Send her an application. = Sender an application.
- You do not need to drop the h for people to understand you. But many native speakers drop it, so knowing this rule will help your listening.

Can or can't?

- "Can" is usually reduced. You say it with a schwa: /kən/. Lauren can make toothpaste.
- "Can't" is usually said with a clear /æ/ sound, as in "apple" or "answer". I can't make toothpaste.
- So listen for the vowel: weak /ə/ = can; clear /æ/ = can't.

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Many Arabic speakers say small words with a full, clear vowel, so "to" sounds like "too". Use the weak schwa in function words (/tə/, /kən/), but keep a clear /æ/ in "can't".

Practice

Recordings: play the named clip from the folder `E:\personal-tutor\materials\library\esl-b1-speaking\attachments\03.05-reduced-words\` or from the book's web page (see Watch online).

1. Video. Watch "De-Stressed Function Words" (see Watch online).

2. Listen and repeat. Play `Reduced_Words_Examples.m4a`. Repeat each example sentence in the table. Then say the sentences to your tutor.

3. Missing function words. Play `Listening_Practice_-_Reduced_Function_Words.m4a`. Write the missing function word (sentence 1 has two).

1. . . . today I'm going ____ show you how ____ make zero waste toothpaste.
2. I've been using it ____ years . . .
3. I grew up in Oxford which is ____ small city in England . . .
4. Where ____ you living now?
5. I have a younger brother ____ an older sister . . .
6. Would you like coffee ____ tea?
7. You can't come to Berlin ____ not eat a Currywurst!
8. The Berlin wall stands ____ a memorial to freedom.
9. The park . . . was full ____ wild deer and other animals.
10. Do you ____ a car?

4. Andy's job. Play `Summary_-_Andy's_job.m4a`. Write the missing function words. Notice how they are reduced. Andy is from Oxford, but (1) ____ lives in San Diego. In (2) ____ free time, Andy likes to read (3) ____ go running. He also cooks, plays the guitar, and listens (4) ____ podcasts. He avoids eating meat because meat production hurts the environment. Andy is (5) ____ farmer. He drives (6) ____ pickup truck. Every day he works outside. He plants (7) ____ waters crops. He also pulls weeds and does harvesting, and (8) ____ repairs fences. He loves working outside (9) ____ taking lots (10) ____ fresh air. Andy teaches other farmers about sustainable agriculture. He wants (11) ____ teach them how (12) ____ protect the environment.

5. Drop the h. Cross out the "h" and link the h word to the word before it. Then rewrite the sentence the way it sounds. Example: Send her an application. = Sender an application.

1. Say goodbye before he leaves.
2. What did he get her for her birthday?
3. She has a lot to do today.
4. Take him out for a walk before dinner.

5. You'll have a lot of friends there.
6. He danced his heart out tonight.

Practise reading the sentences with the h dropped. Record yourself with your phone and listen back. Then watch "How to link words that begin with H" (see Watch online).

6. Listen: drop the h. Play `Listening_Practice_-_Drop_the_H.m4a`. Two words are missing from each sentence.

1. I'll ____ ____ we're leaving.
2. Don't ____ ____ a watch on?
3. ____ ____ get lost?
4. She ____ ____ car into a tree.
5. What ____ ____ name again?
6. I ____ ____ no.
7. Jan ____ ____ book all afternoon.
8. He ____ ____ bus because he slept too late.
9. ____ ____ there?
10. ____ ____ you done?

7. Can or can't? (1) Watch "Can vs. Can't" (see Watch online). Then play `Listening_Practice_1_Can_vs_Can't.m4a`. Underline the word you hear. Example: Lauren (can/can't) make toothpaste.

1. In Berlin, you (can/can't) try curry wurst. It's delicious!
2. You (can/can't) come to Berlin, and not try a curry wurst.
3. You (can/can't) use peppermint or cinnamon flavor in your toothpaste recipe.
4. You (can/can't) use whatever you want to stir the toothpaste.
5. (Can/Can't) you reduce the amount of trash you make?
6. Andy loves to grow vegetables. He (can/can't) grow any vegetables you want.

8. Can or can't? (2) Play `Listening_Practice_2_Can_vs_Can't.m4a`. Underline the word you hear in the 18 sentences of Listening Practice 2 in your lesson material.

9. Can you ...? Answer each question about yourself: "Yes, I can." or "No, I can't." Can you play the guitar / cook / ride a horse / tap dance / sing / fly an airplane / eat spicy food / swim / run fast / sew? Then write two sentences like the book's example: "I learned that Andy can play the guitar, but Brittany can't sew."

10. Review. Play `Review_Reduced_Words.m4a`. Complete the sentences.

1. It's super quick ____ easy ____ make.
2. Combine two tablespoons ____ coconut oil, one tablespoon ____ baking soda, ____ fifteen to twenty drops ____ essential oil.
3. I like ____ use peppermint, ____ you ____ use cinnamon ____ spearmint.

4. I like to use ____ compostable toothbrush ____ a spoon.
5. If it's too hard, put ____ under some warm water ____ ____ few minutes.

11. Record. Underline the function words in the five complete sentences (see the answer key for 10). Practise reading them aloud. Then record yourself. Stress the content words and reduce the function words.

Speak with your tutor

- "Read me sentences with 'can' or 'can't'. Choose randomly. After each one, I say which word I heard. Tell me if I am right."
- "Ask me ten 'Can you ...?' questions. I answer 'Yes, I can' or 'No, I can't' and add one more sentence."
- "Now I ask you 'Can you ...?' questions. Then I tell you what I learned: 'You can ..., but you can't ...'."
- "Say these sentences fast and naturally: 'What did he do?', 'Will he call me?', 'Send her an application.' I repeat after you and drop the h."
- "I will read Lauren's recipe sentences. Tell me if I stress the content words and reduce 'and', 'to', 'of' and 'for'."

Read aloud

- It's SU·per QUICK and EA·sy to MAKE.
- com·BINE TWO TA·ble·spoons of CO·co·nut OIL. (of = /ə/ before a consonant)
- I LIKE to USE PEP·per·mint, but you can USE CIN·na·mon or SPEAR·mint (check).
- If it's TOO HARD, PUT it under some WARM WA·ter for a FEW MIN·utes.
- What did he do? = WHAT didee DO? (↘)
- Will he call me? = Willy CALL me? (↗)
- LAU·ren can MAKE TOOTH·paste. (can = /kən/)
- I CAN'T MAKE TOOTH·paste. (can't = /æ/)

Watch online

- De-Stressed Function Words (Elemental English): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Ro_v3DwdbRA
- "h" deletion with connected speech (Elemental English): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=55vpaD2p4xI
- How to link words that begin with H (Rachel's English): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=QuOw_KnFk3Y
- Can vs. Can't (Elemental English): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=T-XZHX7DpdU
- The book's page for this lesson, with all the recordings: https://human.libretexts.org/Bookshelves/Languages/English_as_a_Second_Language/Book%3A_Speaking_Listening_and_Pronunciation_Projects_for_ELLs_-_Intermediate_Level_(Zemlick)/03%3A_Zero_Waste/3.05%3A_Reduced_Words

Answer key

3. (book) 1 to, to; 2 for; 3 a; 4 are; 5 and; 6 or; 7 and; 8 as; 9 of; 10 have

4. (book) 1 he, 2 his, 3 and, 4 to, 5 a, 6 a, 7 and, 8 he, 9 and, 10 of, 11 to, 12 to

5. (example answer; your spelling can be different)

1. Say goodbye befor-ee leaves.
2. What didee get-ər for-ər birthday?
3. She-əz a lot to do today.
4. Take-əm out for a walk before dinner.
5. You'll-əv a lot of friends there.
6. He danced-iz heart out tonight. (Keep the h in "He" at the start of the sentence, and in "heart", a content word.)

6. (book) 1 tell him; 2 you have; 3 Did he; 4 drove her; 5 was her; 6 told him; 7 read her; 8 missed his; 9 Was he; 10 What have

7. (book) Example: can. 1 can; 2 can't; 3 can; 4 can; 5 Can't; 6 can

8. (book) 1 can't, can; 2 can; 3 can, can't; 4 Can; 5 can; 6 can't; 7 Can, can't; 8 Can, can; 9 can; 10 can't; 11 can't; 12 can; 13 can't; 14 can't, can; 15 can; 16 can't; 17 can; 18 can't

9. (example answer) Yes, I can cook. No, I can't ride a horse. I can swim, but I can't sew.

10. (book) 1 and, to; 2 of, of, and, of; 3 to, but, can, or; 4 a, and; 5 it, for, a

11. Function words: 1 it('s), and, to; 2 of, of, and, to, of; 3 I, to, but, you, can, or; 4 I, to, a, and, a; 5 if, it('s), it, under, some, for, a

My notes